

Blueprints for the disabled

A look into how the disabled use technology to enable their lives and how science is furthering their cause

Meet 42-year-old Eesha Deshpande, a home maker and mother of two. Her mornings are busy. She wakes up, performs her puja, prepares breakfast, sends kids off to school, and then when things get less hectic, sits down in front of her PC and chats online with friends and relatives abroad. Later in the day, she uses the Internet to shop for various goods like gifts and groceries. On the outset, her life appears to be typical day-to-day living. But for Eesha, this may not have been possible without the use of Assistive Technology.

Seven years ago, Eesha lost the use of her left arm and leg as a result of a collision between her Maruti 800 and a goods delivery truck. After various sessions of physical therapy and consultations with rehabilitators, Eesha now gets around

through the use of a motorised wheelchair when she tires of using crutches. Computer use is made possible using a smart combination of speech and handwriting recognition software and hardware.

There are millions of people like Eesha in the world—some are born with debilitating disorders and some are unlucky enough to acquire bodily defects as a result of an unfortunate circumstance. Regardless of what disability one may have, technology strives to perform as a surrogate of the bodily function that was lost, or never was in the first place.

What is technology if it cannot ease away the hurdles felt on a daily basis by a portion of our society? Be it through medicine, physical aids or electronically, technology and the proponents